The Indicators Worth Watching

Ten series that tell you what the market is actually doing — and where to track each one.

FEAR

VIX — Cboe Volatility Index. Thirty-day implied volatility priced off S&P 500 options. Low teens is complacency, above 30 is panic. It spikes far faster than it decays, so the shape of the move tells you more than the level.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/VIXCLS

OIL — US

WTI Crude. Light sweet crude delivered at Cushing, Oklahoma. The US benchmark, and the barrel that feeds domestic refining margins and the price at the pump.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/DCOILWTICO

OIL — GLOBAL

Brent Crude. Seaborne North Sea crude, the global marker. The Brent–WTI spread tells you about export capacity and freight, not only about demand.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/DCOILBRENTEU

GROWTH

ISM PMI. A diffusion index built from purchasing managers: above 50 is expansion, below 50 is contraction. New orders minus inventories is the forward-looking part of the report.
ismworld.org › reports › ism-pmi-reports

RECESSION

High Yield Spreads. The ICE BofA high-yield option-adjusted spread over Treasuries. Credit usually cracks before equities do; sustained widening is the signal, not the absolute number.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/BAMLH0A0HYM2

US STOCKS

S&P 500. Cap-weighted, so the largest names can carry the index while the median stock falls. Check breadth against the headline print before drawing a conclusion.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/SP500

TECH

Nasdaq Composite. Longer duration and more rate-sensitive than the S&P. Its ratio to the S&P 500 is a cleaner read on risk appetite than either index alone.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/NASDAQCOM

INFLATION

CPI. Released monthly by the Bureau of Labor Statistics. Core ex-food-and-energy and the three-month annualised rate say more about the trend than the year-over-year headline.
bls.gov/cpi · fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CPIAUCSL

INTEREST RATES

10-Year Treasury. The discount rate sitting underneath every long-duration asset. Watch the 2s10s spread alongside the level — the slope carries information the yield does not.
fred.stlouisfed.org/series/DGS10

THE DOLLAR

DXY — US Dollar Index. The dollar against six major currencies, with the euro roughly 58% of the basket. A strong dollar tightens global financial conditions and squeezes commodities and emerging markets.
marketwatch.com/investing/index/dxy

GLOBAL TRADE

Baltic Dry Index. The spot cost of moving dry bulk — iron ore, coal, grain — by sea. Real money paid for real cargo, but fleet supply moves it as much as demand does, so not every spike is growth.
tradingeconomics.com/commodity/baltic

Reading Them Together

Levels on their own tell you little. A VIX of 18 means nothing; a VIX of 18 with high yield spreads widening and the dollar bid means something. You are looking for agreement between these series and, more usefully, for divergence.

Credit leads equities. Rates and the dollar set the price of everything else. Oil and the Baltic Dry check the financial economy's story against the physical one. When the tape and the freight rates disagree, one of them is early.

Most of these are daily series, and a weekly glance covers all but the VIX and the ten-year. Set alerts rather than tabs. These are tools for framing questions, not answers, and none of it is investment advice.

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